

the inbuilt computer how fast you want to go. The computer makes decisions about when to use the petrol engine, when to go electric, or when to use a combination of both.

Mass Acceptance...

So why doesn't everybody—at least in the US—just go out and buy a hybrid car? Several celebrities including Cameron Diaz and Leonardo DiCaprio are big fans of their hybrid cars, but the cars still have not made a big impact on the average consumer: misconceptions exist.

For example, people believe that the cars have to be plugged in to get recharged. There's also the common perception that all alternative fuel cars run slow—this, however, isn't true anymore.

Electric cars used to be a little funny-looking, at one point of time, and, unfortunately, this stereotypical image has passed on to hybrids as well. And finally, there's also the question of whether hybrids are indeed the way forward.

The Current Buzz

Many question the very sanity of focusing on hybrid cars for the future: we all know that our crude oil supplies will not last for long. The point raised by these dissenters is quite simply, why waste time on a technology that still pretty much depends on derivatives of crude



Why Are Hybrid Cars A Good Idea?

- ▶ Hybrid cars are good for the environment. They can reduce smog by 90 per cent and use far less petrol than conventional cars.
- ▶ Hybrid cars are economical. They can offer mileages of up to 25 km per litre for city driving—while a typical SUV might travel 8-10 km per litre, or use three times as much petrol for the same distance!
- ▶ Hybrids are better than all-electric cars because hybrid car batteries recharge as you drive so there is no need to plug in repeatedly.
- ▶ Though until a few years ago most electric cars could not match the speeds of fuel-driven cars, today, certain electric and hybrid cars can attain speeds of more than 350 kmph—and let's face it, we really don't need to go any faster than that!

oil? Since hybrids use both fuel and electric motors to power themselves, what happens when the fuel runs out? At best, a mass adoption of hybrid cars will merely delay the inevitable. This is where research for alternative power sources is headed.

Fuel Cells

Don't be fooled by the word "fuel" here, because fuel cell powered cars generally use a combination of hydrogen and oxygen. Basically, in such cars, hydrogen is combined with oxygen to produce energy, and only one by-product is formed—hydrogen oxide, better known as water! There are, therefore, no harmful gases released into the atmosphere to damage the ozone layer; there's enough fuel to go around,

and if you get thirsty, you can always pop open your car and have a drink of pure water! It's only a matter of time before we see fuel cell cars becoming commercial, as fully functional prototypes already exist.

The Honda 2006 FCX Fuel Cell

A prototype of this car was recently unveiled by Honda. The car has a 107 horsepower engine that is powered by hydrogen. The car can store a little over 150 litres of highly compressed hydrogen, has a top speed of 150 kmph, and mileage of 190 km on a full tank. The car is as stylish as any other in the sedan class, and as we mentioned earlier, does not pollute at all.

Looking Forward

In the near future, it's obvious that alternative technologies and fuels will be needed, and the first place these changes will occur will be with our gas guzzling transport vehicles. Thanks to research being done on electric, hybrid and fuel cell powered cars, we at least have a vision of what destiny holds in store.

The only thing standing in the way of prototypes hitting the production lines is mass acceptance. It's time we started to think for the future, think about saving the environment, as well as think about how much money we will save in the long run. Now that you know better, the choice is all yours! ■

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Ford Escape

Ford has also unveiled a petrol-electric hybrid Escape sport-utility and it's being offered to consumers in the US since last year.

Ford claims that the Escape Hybrid's 2.3-litre four-cylinder engine, 300-volt battery, and 65-kilowatt electric motor provide acceleration



Ford Escape

comparable to the regular Escape's optional 201-hp V-6 engine while delivering 56 to 65 km/litre in the city.

Ford claims that its hybrid-electric system is more sophisticated than those of its competitors, as it has a larger storage battery and the capability of driving on electric power alone.

The price premium over a regular Escape, Ford says, will be roughly equivalent to the savings in fuel that the Escape Hybrid will provide. It costs approximately Rs 13,00,000.